

AutoFilter Enhancements

In Excel 2003, the AutoFilter drop-downs display two new items at the top: Sort Ascending and Sort Descending. These items perform just like the convenient buttons in the 'Standard' toolbar.

Synchronised Scrolling

Another new feature is called 'Compare side-by-side'. This gives you synchronised scrolling when viewing two sheets to compare them. Unfortunately, the actual sheet comparison must be done with your eyes—there's no way to automatically compare.

Statistical Functions

Microsoft's marketing literature refers to 'enhancements' to the statistical functions, but the truth is, these functions have been broken for more than a decade, and they finally return accurate results in Excel 2003.

Office-Wide Enhancements

Excel users will notice a few other differences, which are actually part of the Office-wide enhancements. Excel looks a bit different cosmetically. The toolbar icons now use more colours, and the toolbars themselves have a 3D look.

You'll also find that the toolbars pick up the colours used in the Windows colour scheme. This will not affect those of you who prefer the Windows XP Classic scheme. In fact, there is a downside. Those who don't use the XP Windows themes will find that it's difficult to determine the row and column of the active cell. In the past, the row and column borders of the active cell changed colours. Now the colour change is very subtle.

Another new Office feature is the 'Research' pane, which appears in the 'Task' pane. You can use this to search for information or access premium content (assuming you've purchased a subscription).